

Grief & the Unlived Life

The grief no one sends flowers for: grieving what never was, and what was taken before it had a chance to be.

Austan Sloan • Recover-You

A note before you begin. This guide deals with loss, including the death of people we love, overdose, suicide and childhood harm. Take it in pieces if you need to. There is no right way to read it, and no right way to grieve.

Feeling overwhelmed by what you're reading? Support is here. Call or text 988, Canada's 24/7 Suicide Crisis Helpline • In Alberta, call or text 211 for community, social, health, and government services • In Edmonton and area, call the 24/7 Distress Line at 780-482-HELP (4357) • Call 911 in an emergency.

Not All Grief Comes With a Funeral

When someone dies, the world knows what to do. There's a service. Food shows up at the door. People lower their voices around you, and for a little while everyone agrees that you've lost something real.

But some of the heaviest grief a person can carry never gets any of that. No obituary. No cards. Because what you lost wasn't a person in a casket. It was a childhood that should have been safe. A parent who was there but never really present. Years that disappeared into survival, and then into addiction. A version of yourself that never got the chance to exist.

You can't bury what never got to live. So most of us carry it instead. Usually without a name for it. Often for decades.

This guide covers both kinds of loss: the ones everyone recognizes, and the ones almost nobody does. And the uncomfortable place where two hard truths meet: **what happened to you was not fair, and what you do with it now is still yours.**

Shame says *you* are the problem. Grief says *something was lost*. Only one of those is true.

What Grief Actually Is

Grief isn't a malfunction. It's what attachment feels like when the thing you're attached to is gone, or was never there to begin with.

Grief researcher Mary-Frances O'Connor describes grief as a kind of learning problem. The brain keeps a map of the people we're bonded to: that they exist, that they'll come back, that they'll be there tomorrow. When someone dies, that map doesn't update overnight. Grieving is the slow work of the brain learning a reality it never wanted to learn.

The same logic applies to losses that never involved a death. If you spent your childhood waiting for a parent to become safe, part of your brain may still be waiting. The map was drawn around someone who was supposed to show up. They didn't. And the map never got the update.

Forget the Five Stages

Denial, anger, bargaining, depression, acceptance. Elisabeth Kübler-Ross built those stages from her work with people who were *dying*, not people who were grieving, and research since has found that most bereaved people don't move through grief in tidy steps. In 2017, Stroebe, Schut and Boerner warned health-care professionals that the stage model can do harm, by teaching people they're grieving "wrong" whenever their experience doesn't match the script.

What the evidence supports instead looks more like a pendulum. Stroebe and Schut's Dual Process Model describes healthy grieving as oscillation: time spent facing the loss, and time spent stepping away from it to rebuild a life. Stepping away from grief isn't avoidance. It's part of how grieving works.

Grief doesn't keep a schedule. It comes in waves, often set off by things you didn't see coming.

Feeling okay for a while doesn't mean you're finished.

Feeling it again doesn't mean you've gone backwards.

The Losses Everyone Recognizes

When Someone Dies

For a nervous system already running on high alert, a death can be destabilizing in ways that are hard to explain. It confirms the oldest rule trauma ever taught you: the people you need can disappear, and there is nothing you can do about it. A large national study of bereaved adults found that men in the first two years after losing a close family member showed markedly higher rates of harmful drinking than men who hadn't. If you're in recovery, a death can be one of the most dangerous stretches you'll face.

When the Death Comes With Stigma

Overdose deaths, alcohol-related deaths and suicides tend to arrive wrapped in silence. Researchers who studied families bereaved by drug and alcohol deaths described a **disenfranchised grief**: the loss is just as real, but the stigma attached to how the person died makes it harder to mourn openly. If you've lost someone to addiction, your grief deserves exactly the same room as anyone else's.

When the Person Who Died Is the Person Who Hurt You

Some people feel nothing, then feel guilty for feeling nothing. Some are flattened by sadness. Some feel relief, and then shame for the relief. All of it is normal. You aren't only grieving them. You're grieving the possibility that they would ever change, apologize, or become the person you needed. Death closes the door on repair, and that is its own loss.

A Personal Story: My Mother

My mother died at fifty. Addiction followed her for her whole life, and I was her last child. She held things mostly together until I was born. Then it all fell apart.

There was never a real point of connection between us. What followed was a childhood no child should have. As hard as that was, the deepest scar wasn't any single thing that happened

to me. It was feeling rejected by my own mother, and having her watch it happen without stepping in.

My grief for her moved in a way no stage model would predict. Desperate for her love. Confused about where I fit. Certain I didn't fit anywhere. Then hate. Then I shut it out completely. I told everyone I was fine, that I didn't think about it anymore. I didn't understand yet that not thinking about something and building walls around it are not the same thing. Behind those walls, a belief took hold before I had language for it: that I was broken, that *I* was what was wrong. My addiction became the evidence.

What changed it was understanding. My own addiction taught me something I never wanted to learn: you can love someone deeply and still choose to hurt them, every time you reach for the relief instead of them. That opened the door to empathy. Then I learned what addiction does to a person, and I learned about her own childhood, which was horrific. She didn't hate me. She was in pain her whole life and medicated it the only way she could, with no map to healing. Once addiction moved in, her maternal instincts were gone. She wasn't acting out of malice. She was acting out of pain she never understood.

That understanding didn't change what happened. It changed what I carry. The hate became empathy, and then love.

Her story and mine are the architecture behind everything on this site. When she was my age, there were no real tools. There was "get over it." There was "that didn't happen." Without that knowledge, a lot of people before us were doomed to repeat what was done to them. **Now we know better.** The education I found and the science we have now are what let me break the intergenerational cycle. Those of us still suffering deserve every one of those tools. She never got them. That's what this site is for.

Survivor's Guilt

| *"Why do I get another chance when they didn't?"*

If you've been in recovery for any length of time, you probably know someone who didn't make it. Survivor's guilt is the sense that your survival is undeserved, or that it somehow came at someone else's expense. It rarely shows up as a clear thought. More often it shows up in behaviour:

Hiding or downplaying milestones in sobriety, because celebrating feels disrespectful to the people who died.

Sabotaging a job, a relationship or a stretch of stability right when things start going well.

Holding back in therapy because part of you doesn't believe you've earned the right to get better.

Living as though you owe a debt you can never finish paying.

Survivor's guilt often tangles grief together with shame. The loss is real. The verdict attached to it is not.

| *You don't have to earn your survival. You only have to stop refusing it.*

Ambiguous Grief: Grieving What Never Was

Some losses never have an ending. No death certificate. No date to mark. Family therapist and researcher Pauline Boss named these losses **ambiguous loss**, and described two kinds: someone physically gone but still psychologically present, and someone physically present but psychologically gone. Boss's own examples of the second kind include addiction.

For a lot of trauma survivors, that second kind describes an entire childhood. Psychotherapist Francis Weller names one of grief's "gates" as *what we expected and did not receive*. You can't mourn a loss you were never allowed to see. Here is what that grief can look like:

The childhood you didn't get. The chance to just be a kid, lost to watching the adults for danger.

The parent you needed. You can love them and still grieve who they never became.

Who you might have been. The talents nobody encouraged. The life interrupted before it started.

The lost years. Time spent surviving, then using. Refusing to count them doesn't bring them back.

Here, but gone. Loving someone in active addiction, or being the one others grieved while you were still alive.

The substance itself. For many of us, it was the most reliable relationship we had.

The world you used in. Leaving it behind was the right call. It was also a loss.

The mask. Even the false self that got you through is something you grieve.

Boss is blunt about what this kind of grief needs. Not closure. Waiting for a clean ending keeps you frozen. The goal is learning to carry the loss in a way that lets you keep living.

Grieving Who You Might Have Been

For years I carried resentment toward what happened to me. If I'm honest, some of it was closer to hate. But eventually I had to accept what couldn't be undone: what could have been never was, and what remains is all that matters now.

What surprised me was this: allowing myself to grieve didn't weaken me. It stabilized me. The grief didn't disappear, but it changed shape, from something that was happening to me into something I was moving through.

This grief also arrives late. It shows up when you watch someone else's kid get the encouragement you never got, or when you finally get some stability and realize how much of your life was lived without it. Healing often makes this grief louder before it makes it quieter, because for the first time you're safe enough to see what was missing.

Grief Without Permission

In 1989, grief researcher Kenneth Doka coined the term **disenfranchised grief** for grief that isn't openly acknowledged, socially supported or publicly mourned. Nobody sends a card when you realize your childhood wasn't safe. There's no bereavement leave for the decade you lost to addiction. And the shutdowns often come from the people who should understand best: "That was a long time ago." "At least you're sober now." "Just be grateful for what you have."

Gratitude is a real tool. Used as a muzzle, it just teaches people to perform being okay, which is exactly what most of us were doing before we got here.

On the "No Regrets" Cliché

I know the approved recovery answer: "I wouldn't change a thing. My struggle made me who I am." It's tidy. It makes for a good bumper sticker. But if you're asking me to be honest? Hell yes, I wish things had been different. I wish the people who were supposed to protect me had. In my experience, that kind of peace usually comes after the grief, not instead of it.

True strength isn't pretending the damage was a gift. It's recognizing the miracle of the humanity I managed to hold onto in spite of it.

Two Things Are True

Most people get stuck on one side of a line. Some never let themselves feel how unfair it was. Others feel the unfairness so completely that moving forward starts to feel like letting the people who hurt them off the hook. Healing asks you to stand on both sides of that line at once.

THE FIRST TRUTH

It Happened, and It Wasn't Fair

Nobody asked a child for consent. Honouring that means letting it be as big as it actually was: acknowledging it, and feeling the anger and sadness without tidying them up for anyone else's comfort. Skip this part and the injustice goes underground and comes back as shame.

THE SECOND TRUTH

It's Still Ours to Carry Forward

It isn't fair that the work of healing falls on the people who were hurt. It falls on us anyway. Responsibility isn't blame. It means you're the only one who can decide where it goes from here. For a lot of us, that's the first real power we've ever had.

Pauline Boss calls this **both/and thinking**. DBT builds the same skill through radical acceptance: accepting reality completely, not because it's okay, but because fighting it keeps you stuck inside it.

It wasn't your fault. It is your responsibility. Grief is what makes both of those bearable.

Where Grief and Addiction Meet

In 2008, a UCLA team led by Mary-Frances O'Connor found that in bereaved women whose grief had stayed raw and unrelenting, reminders of the person they'd lost activated the nucleus accumbens, part of the brain's reward system, and the more they yearned, the stronger that activation was. It was a small study, so it shows an overlap, not a cause. But grief that can't move forward can involve the same reward circuitry as craving.

It may also be part of why sobriety so often *uncovers* grief instead of resolving it. Take away the thing that numbed the loss, and the loss is still there.

Mourning Is Part of Healing, Not a Detour

Judith Herman's model of trauma recovery has three stages: safety and stabilization, remembrance and mourning, and reconnection. Mourning is the middle of recovery, not something in its way. Herman herself was clear that the stages overlap and rarely run in a straight line. Pacing matters: grief work started before there's enough stability to hold it can overwhelm a person. Not every loss needs digging into. But if one keeps showing up in your recovery, as irritability, numbness or cravings, it's asking for attention.

| *Safety first. Then grief, at a pace you can hold.*

Name What You've Lost

Grief that has a name is easier to carry than grief that doesn't. Tick any that are yours. There's no score and no right number.

Losses other people could see

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Someone I loved who died | ☐ A relationship that ended |
| ☐ Someone lost to overdose or substance use | ☐ A home, job or community I can't go back to |
| ☐ Someone lost to suicide | ☐ Someone who hurt me, and who is now gone |

Losses no one else could see

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ The childhood I should have had | ☐ My ability to trust |
| ☐ A feeling of safety I never got to have | ☐ My faith, or my sense that life makes sense |
| ☐ The parent I needed | ☐ My innocence |
| ☐ A family that was never what it looked like | ☐ The mask that got me through |
| ☐ The person I might have become | |

Losses that came with addiction and recovery

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Years lost to using | ☐ Someone still using who I've had to step back from |
| ☐ Relationships that didn't survive my addiction | ☐ The substance, and what it did for me |
| ☐ Moments I missed that won't come again | ☐ The people and places I used with |

A place to start. Pick one loss you ticked and write it here in a single sentence. Then write one line to it, the way you'd write to a person.

Moving Through It

There's no way around grief. There's only through, and *through* doesn't mean *over*. Pete Walker describes grieving as working through four channels: angering, crying, verbal ventilating and feeling. Most of us were taught early that all four were dangerous. Grief also needs a witness: saying it out loud to someone who doesn't flinch does something that thinking about it alone never will.

Give it shape

Write an unsendable letter to the person you lost, the parent you needed, or the kid you were.

Mark your losses on a timeline (Chart Your Life). Seeing them in sequence can explain things nothing else could.

Make a small ritual: a date, a place, an object.

Let it move

Keep a bond where it helps. Staying connected to what you lost can be part of healthy grief.

Find people who know this loss.

Let the anger count. It's one of grief's channels, not a sign you're doing it wrong.

Protect your recovery

Treat anniversaries, holidays and funerals as high-risk days. Plan for them ahead of time.

Tell someone when a loss hits. Grief carried in isolation is where relapse tends to live.

If the urge to use rises with the grief, that isn't failure. It's information. Reach for a regulation tool first.

When grief gets stuck

Most grief gradually softens. For some people it doesn't. In 2022 the DSM-5-TR added Prolonged Grief Disorder: grief after a death that, a year or more later (six months for children and teens), still involves intense yearning for or preoccupation with the person nearly every day, plus at least three other symptoms such as feeling part of you died too, emotional numbness or intense loneliness. It also has to cause real distress or disrupt daily life beyond what's expected in your culture or faith. Missing someone intensely a year later is not, on its own, a disorder. It's treatable, and worth raising with a professional who understands both grief and trauma.

Grief support in Canada and Alberta

MyGrief.ca: online grief modules from Canadian Virtual Hospice.

Hospice Calgary (hospicecalgary.com): grief counselling and support groups for children, teens and adults.

Moms Stop the Harm (momsstoptheharm.com): peer support for families who've lost someone to substance use (Healing Hearts) or love someone still using (Holding Hope).

Health Link 811: 24/7 health advice and referrals anywhere in Alberta.

What Remains

You can't go back and give yourself the childhood you deserved. You can't get the years back. You can't turn the people who hurt you into the people you needed, and you can't bring back the ones who didn't make it.

What you can do is stop pretending none of it mattered. Let it be as unfair as it was. Feel it all the way through. Then pick up what's left, which is more than it looks like from inside the grief, and build something with it.

| *Honour what was lost. Then live like what remains is worth it. Because it is.*

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Sources & Further Reading

These sources provide the research and clinical context for this guide's discussion of grief, ambiguous loss, disenfranchised grief and their connection to trauma and addiction.

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